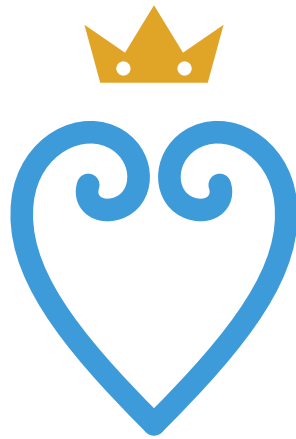


SONIC BRANDING

GAME MUSIC AS FRANCHISE STRATEGY



ONE MELODY, TWENTY YEARS

“Dearly Beloved” and the Musical Coherence of Kingdom Hearts

A franchise whose story cannot be summarized, with an identity anyone can state in one sentence. This paper argues the coherence is musical: one piano theme, rearranged for every entry across twenty years, doing the work the storytelling cannot.

When a story cannot carry a brand, how much of the work can a melody do?

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1 | KINGDOM HEARTS IN BUSINESS AND CULTURE

Ask a *Kingdom Hearts* fan to explain the plot and you will be offered a flowchart. The franchise sprawls across more than a dozen games released out of chronological order on half a dozen platforms; its mythology involves time travel, body-sharing, at least three characters who are in some sense the same boy, and a naming convention that produced *Kingdom Hearts 358/2 Days* as an actual product title. Even devoted players joke that nobody fully understands it.

Now ask the same fan what *Kingdom Hearts* feels like, and the flowchart disappears. The answers converge with almost embarrassing consistency: bittersweet, nostalgic, sincere, something about childhood friendship, separation, and growing up. A franchise whose story cannot be summarized produces an emotional signature that can be stated in one sentence by anyone who has touched it.

That combination should not exist. Franchise theory says narrative incoherence dilutes a brand; every fragmented universe from comics to cinema has paid that tax. *Kingdom Hearts* has somehow paid it on the story and skipped it on the identity, and the mechanism is worth explaining. This paper argues that the coherence is musical: a single piano theme by Yoko Shimomura, rearranged for every entry across twenty years, performs the brand-identity work the storytelling cannot, and *Kingdom Hearts* is consequently the purest case study available in how a franchise can locate its identity almost entirely in sound.

2 | A BRAND PROBLEM WITH NO CLEAN SOLUTION

Begin with what the franchise had to reconcile, because the difficulty is the point. *Kingdom Hearts* (2002) was a corporate handshake made playable: Disney's family-facing warmth crossed with Square's operatic melodrama, Donald Duck sharing a battlefield with characters designed for Japanese role-playing games.¹ The two parents brought incompatible tones, incompatible audiences, and incompatible expectations about how much a children's story is allowed to hurt.

The obvious risk was that the crossover would read as a licensing stunt (Mickey Mouse as marketing, not meaning). The franchise's answer, sustained across two decades, was not narrative (the narrative made things worse) but tonal: an unwavering emotional register that belonged to neither parent and therefore proved the hybrid was its own thing. And that register was established, before a single line of dialogue, by forty-five seconds of piano on a title screen.

¹The original *Kingdom Hearts* was released by Squaresoft (later Square Enix) for PlayStation 2 in March 2002 (Japan), directed by Tetsuya Nomura.

3 | THE ASSET: SIMPLICITY AS A DESIGN DECISION

“Dearly Beloved” is a spare piece: a gently rocking accompaniment under a wistful, singable melody, somewhere between a lullaby and an elegy. It plays on the menu screen: structurally the first and last thing a player hears of any *Kingdom Hearts* game, the frame around every session. Shimomura has said the melody arrived almost unbidden; whatever its origin, its properties are the strategically interesting part.²

The melody is minimal enough to survive unlimited transformation and distinctive enough to be identified from three notes. In branding terms it has the same properties as the strongest visual marks: reducible, reproducible, unmistakable. A Stratocaster outline is wood any factory can shape, and the value was never the geometry but the history attached to it; “Dearly Beloved” is eight bars any student pianist can play, and the value is twenty years of accumulated feeling attached to those bars. The difference is that Square Enix, unlike Fender, never had to fight anyone for the shape. You can copy a melody’s notes; you cannot copy what it retrieves.

4 | VARIATION AS LIFECYCLE MARKETING

Here is where *Kingdom Hearts* stops being an example and becomes a method. Nearly every entry in the series opens with a *new arrangement* of the same theme, each calibrated to that game’s emotional register, and the catalog of variations reads like a controlled experiment in what arrangement alone can do.³

Kingdom Hearts II expands the solo piano into full orchestra as the series’ scope widens. The *358/2 Days* version hands the melody to a lonely flute over harp for the series’ most tragic side story. *Birth by Sleep* receives a grander, mythic treatment for its prequel; *Re:coded* runs faster and lighter for a sligher game; *Dream Drop Distance* slows the theme into something unresolved and dreamlike. By *Melody of Memory* (the series’ own rhythm-game retrospective) the theme arrives jazz-inflected and celebratory: the franchise playing its own memory back with a smile. Inside the games the theme propagates further, seeding named variations (“Friends in My Heart,” the concert-scale “Fantasia alla Marcia”) until the title-screen melody quietly underwrites whole stretches of score.



ONE THEME, SEVEN REGISTERS: “DEARLY BELOVED” ACROSS THE SERIES

²Square Enix, “Kingdom Hearts: Yoko Shimomura talks Dearly Beloved,” Square Enix Blog.

³Arrangement history per the *Kingdom Hearts* wiki (khwiki.com), “Dearly Beloved.”



ONE POSE, THREE ERAS: SORA (2002), ROXAS (2009), AND SORA AGAIN (2019):
THE COVER ART PERFORMS VISUALLY WHAT “DEARLY BELOVED” PERFORMS MUSICALLY

Promotional artwork © Square Enix / Disney, illustrations by Tetsuya Nomura.

Read the sequence as a marketer rather than a musicologist and the pattern sharpens. A player who was ten for the 2002 original was in high school for *Kingdom Hearts II*’s orchestral swell and an adult for the finale. Each arrangement meets the returning player at their new age with the same melody at a new maturity, which is precisely the emotional transaction the franchise’s story of growing up and drifting apart keeps promising and cannot reliably deliver. The reliability the eighty-hour narratives never achieve, the title screen delivers in under a minute.

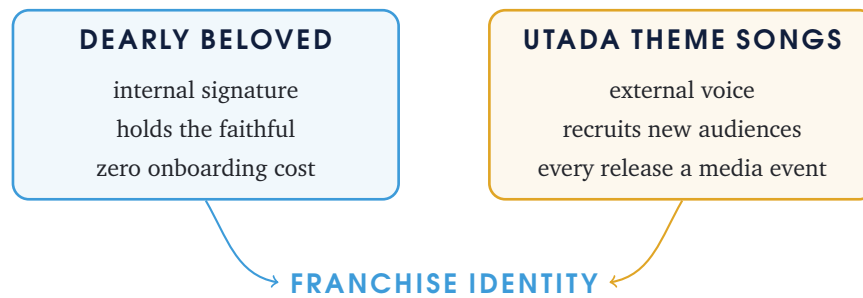
The community completed the system unprompted. Ranking the “Dearly Beloved” variations is a recurring genre of fan content (videos, threads, playlists), which is to say the brand asset generates its own earned media. A sales force you do not pay is also one you cannot redirect, but Square Enix has never needed to redirect this one. All it has to do is never skip the theme, and never leave it unchanged.

5 | THE UTADA LAYER: AN EXTERNAL VOICE FOR AN INTERNAL FEELING

Above the instrumental signature sits the franchise’s second sonic pillar, and its function is different enough to matter. Utada Hikaru, then the biggest voice in J-pop, wrote and sang the theme songs for the original game (“Hikari” / “Simple and Clean”), its sequel (“Passion” / “Sanctuary”), and, after a thirteen-year gap that only sharpened demand, *Kingdom Hearts III* (“Face My Fears,” with Skrillex; “Don’t Think Twice”).⁴

Notice the division of labor. “Dearly Beloved” is internal: it holds the faithful, and its meaning is illegible to outsiders. The Utada songs are external: bilingual by design,

⁴“Music of Kingdom Hearts,” Wikipedia; theme-song discography across *Kingdom Hearts* (2002), *Kingdom Hearts II* (2005), and *Kingdom Hearts III* (2019).



TWO SONIC PILLARS, ONE BRAND: ATTACHMENT INSIDE, RECRUITMENT OUTSIDE

released as pop singles, carrying the franchise across the same bridge the brand itself had to cross: Japan to the West, Disney’s audience to Square’s. Each new mainline entry reopened with an Utada song, making the music a release event before the game was one; “Face My Fears” functioned as global marketing for *Kingdom Hearts III* weeks before launch. One asset deepens attachment; the other recruits. A franchise that had only the theme would age with its fans; a franchise that had only the pop star would have no floor under its identity. The portfolio needs both, and *Kingdom Hearts* has managed both for its entire existence.

6 | WHAT THE MUSIC DOES THAT THE STORY CANNOT

It is worth being precise about the division of labor between sound and story, because the story is not failing at its job. The narrative’s complexity generates the deep-fan behaviors that sustain a community between releases: theorizing, wiki-editing, timeline-untangling. What it cannot generate is accessibility. The plot is a barrier to entry, and every sequel raises it.

The music is the bridge over that barrier. A lapsed player who abandoned the timeline two spin-offs ago hears the opening bars of “Dearly Beloved” and is returned, instantly and without homework, to full emotional membership in the franchise. In brand terms, the melody is the only asset in the property with zero onboarding cost and universal reach. The nearest analogies come from outside games (the Bond theme, or a luxury house reissuing its signature pattern in new materials each season), but *Kingdom Hearts* executes the discipline more rigorously than either, because here the variation itself carries meaning: the arrangement tells the returning audience how much time has passed and how the story now feels about itself.

7 | DID ANYONE INTEND THIS?

Honesty is owed here, because the account above reads like a twenty-year plan, and it almost certainly was not one. Shimomura wrote a beautiful title theme for a 2002 crossover with no guarantee of a sequel. The decision to rearrange rather than replace it was, at first, plausibly just good taste: composers return to good material. Utada’s

involvement began as a high-end commission, not a two-decade architecture.

This is the recurring trap of strategy writing: emergent results and creative instinct are easy to mistake for deliberate intent, and a coherent plan is easiest to narrate after the fact. But as with all discovered strategies, the test is what the company did once the pattern became visible, and by that test the intent is now undeniable. Twenty years in, the theme has never been skipped and never left unchanged; the variations are commissioned, sequenced, and marketed as a set; the rhythm-game retrospective monetizes the songbook directly. Square Enix may have discovered the strategy by accident. It operates it on purpose. Discovered strategies still compound.

8 | WHAT A COMMUNICATIONS TEAM SHOULD TAKE FROM THIS

None of the above is only theory, because every mechanism in this paper has a press-desk equivalent. Four translate directly, and a fifth is still waiting to be built.

Sonic assets are press hooks. A beloved theme generates coverage a patch note never will: anniversaries of a soundtrack, a new arrangement, a concert announcement, a vinyl reissue. Each is a story a games or music journalist can actually file. A communications calendar for a franchise with musical equity should treat the score as a recurring beat, not a one-time launch asset.

Theme songs are launch architecture. “Face My Fears” did the work of a global campaign weeks before *Kingdom Hearts III* shipped: radio play, chart coverage, and a collaboration headline (Utada × Skrillex) that reached far outside the gaming press. The lesson for a PR team is sequencing: a music reveal is its own embargo-worthy event, with its own press list, sitting upstream of the release-date story.

Seed the fan economy; never direct it. The ranking videos, covers, and playlists around “Dearly Beloved” are earned media that no budget could buy and no agency could commission without killing it. The practitioner’s job is supply, not control: official uploads to link, composer interviews to quote, stems and sheet music to build from, anniversaries to react to.

The composer is a spokesperson. Shimomura interviews humanize a corporate franchise and open a second press vertical, music and culture outlets, that most game campaigns never touch. Putting a composer forward costs little and differentiates coverage precisely because so few publishers think to do it.

Build the concert institution. Here the franchise has left its largest move on the table. *Kingdom Hearts* has tested the live model twice, with the Orchestra -World Tour- in 2017 (eighteen performances across three continents, for the series’ fifteenth anniversary) and -World of Tres- in 2019 (timed to *Kingdom Hearts III*), and both sold well enough that extra dates were added mid-announcement.⁵ But both were event marketing, tied to an

⁵Kingdom Hearts Orchestra -World Tour- (2017) and -World of Tres- (2019); performance history per khwiki.com.

anniversary or a release, and then retired. Final Fantasy's *Distant Worlds* demonstrates the alternative: a permanent concert brand, running continuously since 2007 across well over a hundred performances, staffed partly by local orchestras and choirs so that every stop embeds the franchise in a city's own musical community. For a series whose central asset is a piano theme its audience has aged with, a standing concert series converts the arrangement catalog into recurring revenue and, for the communications team, a rolling press calendar: every city announcement is a local media event, twice, first when tickets go on sale and again when the hall sells out. The demand has been proven twice. The institution has not been built.

9 | CONCLUSION: THE MELODY IS THE BRAND

Kingdom Hearts should be a cautionary tale about narrative sprawl, and by every conventional measure of franchise coherence it is one. That it is simultaneously one of the most emotionally coherent properties in games is not a paradox but a finding: coherence was delegated to a single asset simple enough to rearrange forever and protected enough never to be omitted, with a pop star's voice layered above it to do the recruiting the melody could not.

The general lesson is uncomfortable for anyone who believes brands are built in strategy decks. The most durable identity system in modern game franchising is eight bars of piano, maintained with two rules a composer could write on an index card: always play it, never play it the same way. Everything else (the corporate handshake, the impossible timeline, the three boys who are one boy) turned out to be negotiable. The story resets, contradicts, and confounds; the melody returns, changed, and unmistakably itself. Which is, in the end, what the franchise has been about all along, and what a brand is.

